

Project Failure Diagnostic

1. Problem Definition

What exact customer problem are we solving?

How is this problem currently solved?

What alternatives exist, and why are we choosing this one?

What does “done” mean in measurable terms?

2. Inputs and Discovery

Do we have all required information to begin?

Have we validated the assumptions?

Are the requirements specific enough to execute?

Is there a clear validation scheme for outputs?

3. Domain Knowledge

Do we know the problem by its proper name?

Do we understand the relevant workflow, constraints, and vocabulary?

Do we know who normally solves this problem?

Are we missing subject-matter knowledge that would change the design?

4. Alignment

Do all stakeholders agree on the goal?

Are success criteria shared and explicit?

Is there agreement on scope, priorities, and tradeoffs?

Are incentives aligned with the desired outcome?

5. Decision Rights

Who has authority to make final calls?

Who approves scope, design, and changes?

Can decisions be made quickly enough to keep momentum?

Is there a process for resolving disagreement?

6. Resources and Access

Do we have the time, budget, and people required?

Do we have access to the right tools, systems, and data?

Do we have access to PM, domain experts, and process owners?

Are dependencies realistic for the timeline?

7. Principle and Governance

Is there a planning framework or execution template?

Are intermediate milestones and metrics defined?

Are deadlines based on capacity and constraints?

Is there a method for tradeoff decisions when reality changes?

8. Feedback and Control

Are we getting regular signal about progress?

Can we detect failure early?

Are we reviewing and correcting course often enough?

Is there a clear postmortem or learning loop?

Fast Diagnostic Questions

If a project is failing, ask these in order:

Did we define the problem correctly?

Do we know enough to solve it?

Are the right people aligned on the same outcome?

Can the team actually make decisions and execute?

Do we have enough time, access, and support?

Are we measuring progress in a useful way?

Short Taxonomy

You could group nearly all execution failures into this structure:

Unknown problem: the wrong thing is being built.

Unknown method: the team does not know how to solve it.

Unknown authority: the team cannot decide.

Unknown capacity: the team cannot execute.

Unknown standard: there is no agreed definition of success.

Unknown control: the team cannot tell whether it is on track.

A Practical Rule

If you want a simple heuristic:

Inputs tell you what to do.

Knowledge tells you how to do it.

Resources let you do it.

Principles/governance keep you from doing it randomly.